little frequented, but of which the host is entirely devoted to me. I will go there, where I expect to find letters, and you go to the first tavern in the town, to L'Epée du Grand Henri for instance, refresh yourselves, and in two hours be upon the jetty; our boat is waiting for us there.'

The matter being thus decided, the two friends found, about two hundred paces further, the tavern indicated. Their horses were fed, but not unsaddled; the grooms supped, for it was already late, and their two masters, impatient to return, appointed a place of meeting with them on the jetty and desired them on no account to exchange a word with any one. It is needless to say that this caution concerned Blaisois alone—long enough since it had been a useless one to Grimaud.

Athos and Aramis walked down toward the port. From their dress, covered with dust, and from a certain easy manner by means of which a man accustomed to travel is always recognizable, the two friends excited the attention of a few promenaders. There was more especially one upon whom their arrival had produced a decided impression. This man, whom they had noticed from the first for the same reason they had themselves been remarked by others, was walking in a listless way up and down the jetty. From the moment he perceived them he did not cease to look at them and seemed to burn with the wish to speak to them.

On reaching the jetty Athos and Aramis stopped to look at a little boat made fast to a pile and ready rigged as if waiting to start.

'That is doubtless our boat,' said Athos.

'Yes,' replied Aramis, 'and the sloop out there making ready to sail must be that which is to take us to our destination; now,' continued he, 'if only De Winter does not keep us waiting. It is not at all amusing here; there is not a single woman passing.'

'Hush!' said Athos, 'we are overheard.'

In truth, the walker, who, during the observations of the two friends, had passed and repassed behind them several times, stopped at the name of De Winter; but as his face betrayed no emotion at mention of this name, it might have been by chance he stood so still.

'Gentlemen,' said the man, who was young and pale, bowing with ease and courtesy, 'pardon my curiosity, but I see you come from Paris, or at least that you are strangers at Boulogne.'

'We come from Paris, yes,' replied Athos, with the same courtesy; 'what is there we can do for you?'

'Sir,' said the young man, 'will you be so good as to tell me if it be true that Cardinal Mazarin is no longer minister?'

'That is a strange question,' said Aramis.

'He is and he is not,' replied Athos; 'that is to say, he is dismissed by one-half of France, but by intrigues and promises he makes the other half sustain him; you will perceive that this may last a long time.'

'However, sir,' said the stranger, 'he has neither fled nor is in prison?'

'No, sir, not at this moment at least.'

'Sirs, accept my thanks for your politeness,' said the young man, retreating.

'What do you think of that interrogator?' asked Aramis.

'I think he is either a dull provincial person or a spy in search of information.'

'And you replied to him with that notion?'

'Nothing warranted me to answer him otherwise; he was polite to me and I was so to him.'

'But if he be a spy— '

'What do you think a spy would be about here? We are not living in the time of Cardinal Richelieu, who would have closed the ports on bare suspicion.'

'It matters not; you were wrong to reply to him as you did,' continued Aramis, following with his eyes the young man, now vanishing behind the cliffs.

'And you,' said Athos, 'you forget that you committed a very different kind of imprudence in pronouncing Lord de Winter's name. Did you not see that at that name the young man stopped?'

'More reason, then, when he spoke to you, for sending him about his business.'

'A quarrel?' asked Athos.

'And since when have you become afraid of a quarrel?'

'I am always afraid of a quarrel when I am expected at any place and when such a quarrel might possibly prevent my reaching it. Besides, let me own something to you. I am anxious to see that young man nearer.'

'And wherefore?'

'Aramis, you will certainly laugh at me, you will say that I am always repeating the same thing, you will call me the most timorous of visionaries; but to whom do you see a resemblance in that young man?'

'In beauty or on the contrary?' asked Aramis, laughing.

'In ugliness, in so far as a man can resemble a woman.'

'Ah! Egad!' cried Aramis, 'you set me thinking. No, in truth you are no visionary, my dear friend, and now I think of it—you—yes, i'faith, you're right—those delicate, yet firm-set lips, those eyes which seem always at the command of the intellect and never of the heart! Yes, it is one of Milady's bastards!'

'You laugh Aramis.'

'From habit, that is all. I swear to you, I like no better than yourself to meet that viper in my path.'

'Ah! here is De Winter coming,' said Athos.

'Good! one thing now is only awanting and that is, that our grooms should not keep us waiting.'

'No,' said Athos. 'I see them about twenty paces behind my lord. I recognise Grimaud by his long legs and his determined slouch. Tony carries our muskets.'

'Then we set sail to-night?' asked Aramis, glancing toward the west, where the sun had left a single golden cloud, which, dipping into the ocean, appeared by degrees to be extinguished.

'Probably,' said Athos.

'*Diable!*' resumed Aramis, 'I have little fancy for the sea by day, still less at night; the sounds of wind and wave, the frightful movements of the vessel; I confess I prefer the convent of Noisy.'

Athos smiled sadly, for it was evident that he was thinking of other things as he listened to his friend and moved toward De Winter.

'What ails our friend?' said Aramis, 'he resembles one of Dante's damned, whose neck Apollyon has dislocated and who are ever looking at their heels. What the devil makes him glower thus behind him?'

When De Winter perceived them, in his turn he advanced toward them with surprising rapidity.

'What is the matter, my lord?' said Athos, 'and what puts you out of breath thus?'

Chapter XLIII

In Which it is Proved that First Impulses are Oftentimes the Best

THE three gentlemen took the road to Picardy, a road so well known to them and which recalled to Athos and Aramis some of the most picturesque adventures of their youth.

'If Mousqueton were with us,' observed Athos, on reaching the spot where they had had a dispute with the paviers, 'how he would tremble at passing this! Do you remember, Aramis, that it was here he received that famous bullet wound?'

'By my faith, 'twould be excusable in him to tremble,' replied Aramis, 'for even I feel a shudder at the recollection; hold, just above that tree is the little spot where I thought I was killed.'

It was soon time for Grimaud to recall the past. Arriving before the inn at which his master and himself had made such an enormous repast, he approached Athos and said, showing him the airhole of the cellar:

'Sausages!'

Athos began to laugh, for this juvenile escapade of his appeared to be as amusing as if some one had related it of another person.

At last, after travelling two days and a night, they arrived at Boulogne toward the evening, favoured by magnificent weather. Boulogne was a strong position, then almost a deserted town, built entirely on the heights; what is now called the lower town did not then exist.

'Gentlemen,' said De Winter, on reaching the gate of the town, 'let us do here as at Paris—let us separate to avoid suspicion. I know an inn,

The sun had left a single golden cloud

'Nothing,' replied De Winter; 'nothing; and yet in passing the heights it seemed to me— ' and he again turned round.

Athos glanced at Aramis.

'But let us go,' continued De Winter; 'let us be off; the boat must be waiting for us and there is our sloop at anchor—do you see it there? I wish I were on board already,' and he looked back again.

'He has seen him,' said Athos, in a low tone, to Aramis.

They had reached the ladder which led to the boat. De Winter made the grooms who carried the arms and the porters with the luggage descend first and was about to follow them.

At this moment Athos perceived a man walking on the seashore parallel to the jetty, and hastening his steps, as if to reach the other side of the port, scarcely twenty steps from the place of embarking. He fancied in the darkness that he recognised the young man who had questioned him. Athos now descended the ladder in his turn, without losing sight of the young man. The latter, to make a short cut, had appeared on a sluice.

'He certainly bodes us no good,' said Athos; 'but let us embark; once out at sea, let him come.'

And Athos sprang into the boat, which was immediately pushed off and which soon sped seawards under the efforts of four stalwart rowers.

But the young man had begun to follow, or rather to advance before the boat. She was obliged to pass between the point of the jetty, surmounted by a beacon just lighted, and a rock which jutted out. They saw him in the distance climbing the rock in order to look down upon the boat as it passed.

'Ay, but,' said Aramis, 'that young fellow is decidedly a spy.'

'Which is the young man?' asked De Winter, turning around.

'He who followed us and spoke to us awaits us there; behold!'

De Winter turned and followed the direction of Aramis's finger. The beacon bathed with light the little strait through which they were about to pass and the rock where the young man stood with bare head and crossed arms.

'It is he!' exclaimed De Winter, seizing the arm of Athos; 'it is he! I thought I recognised him and I was not mistaken.'

'Whom do you mean?' asked Aramis.

'Milady's son,' replied Athos.

'Well,' said Aramis, 'what do you say to that?'

'I say, my dear D'Herblay, that it is almost sacrilege to distrust Providence when one has such friends, and therefore we will divide the pistoles from Porthos, as we divided the louis sent by D'Artagnan.'

The division being made by the light of Bazin's taper, the two friends continued their road and a quarter of an hour later they had joined De Winter at the Porte Saint Denis.

The two friends mounted, as did their servants. At the corner of the Quai they encountered Bazin, who was running breathlessly.

'Oh, sir!' exclaimed he, 'thank Heaven I have arrived in time. Monsieur Porthos has just been to your house and has left this for you, saying that the letter was important and must be given to you before you left.'

'Good,' said Aramis, taking a purse which Bazin presented to him. 'What is this?'

'Wait, your reverence, there is a letter.'

'You know I have already told you that if you ever call me anything but chevalier I will break every bone in your body. Give me the letter.'

'How can you read?' asked Athos, 'it is as dark as a cold oven.'

'Wait,' said Bazin, striking a flint, and setting afire a twisted wax-light, with which he started the church candles. Thus illumined, Aramis read the following epistle:

> My dear D'Herblay,
>
> I learned from D'Artagnan who has embraced me on the part of the Comte de la Fère and yourself, that you are setting out on a journey which may perhaps last two or three months; as I know that you do not like to ask money of your friends I offer you some of my own accord. Here are two hundred pistoles, which you can dispose of as you wish and return to me when opportunity occurs. Do not fear that you put me to inconvenience; if I want money I can send for some to any of my châteaux; at Bracieux alone, I have twenty thousand francs in gold. So, if I do not send you more it is because I fear you would not accept a larger sum.
>
> I address you, because you know, that although I esteem him from my heart I am a little awed by the Comte de la Fère; but it is understood that what I offer you I offer him at the same time.
>
> I am, as I trust you do not doubt, your devoted
>
> Du Vallon de Bracieux de Pierrefonds.

'The monk!' exclaimed Grimaud.

The young man heard these words and bent so forward over the rock that one might have supposed he was about to precipitate himself from it.

'Yes, it is I, my uncle—I, the son of Milady—I, the monk—I, the secretary and friend of Cromwell—*I know you now*, both you and your companions.'

In that boat sat three men, unquestionably brave, whose courage no man would have dared dispute; nevertheless, at that voice, that accent and those gestures, they felt a chill access of terror cramp their veins. As for Grimaud, his hair stood on end and drops of sweat ran down his brow.

'Ah!' exclaimed Aramis, 'that is the nephew, the monk, and the son of Milady, as he says himself.'

'Alas, yes,' murmured De Winter.

'Then wait,' said Aramis; and with the terrible coolness which on important occasions he showed, he took one of the muskets from Tony, shouldered and aimed it at the young man, who stood, like the accusing angel, upon the rock.

'Fire!' cried Grimaud, unconsciously.

Athos threw himself on the muzzle of the gun and arrested the shot which was about to be fired.

'The devil take you,' said Aramis. 'I had him so well at the point of my gun I should have sent a ball into his breast.'

'It is enough to have killed the mother,' said Athos, hoarsely.

'The mother was a wretch, who struck at us all and at those dear to us.'

'Yes, but the son has done us no harm.'

Grimaud, who had risen to watch the effect of the shot, fell back hopeless, wringing his hands.

The young man burst into a laugh.

'Ah, it is certainly you!' he cried. 'I know you even better now.'

His mocking laugh and threatening words passed over their heads, carried by the breeze, until lost in the depths of the horizon. Aramis shuddered.

'Be calm,' exclaimed Athos, 'for Heaven's sake! have we ceased to be men?'

'No,' said Aramis, 'but that fellow is a fiend; and ask the uncle whether I was wrong to rid him of his dear nephew.'

De Winter only replied by a groan.

'It was all up with him,' continued Aramis; 'ah I much fear that with all your wisdom such mercy yet will prove supernal folly.'

Athos took Lord de Winter's hand and tried to turn the conversation.

'When shall we land in England?' he asked; but De Winter seemed not to hear his words and made no reply.

'Hold, Athos,' said Aramis, 'perhaps there is yet time. See if he is still in the same place.'

Athos turned around with an effort; the sight of the young man was evidently painful to him, and there he still was, in fact, on the rock, the beacon shedding around him, as it were, a doubtful aureole.

'Decidedly, Aramis,' said Athos, 'I think I was wrong not to let you fire.'

'Hold your tongue,' replied Aramis; 'you would make me weep, if such a thing were possible.'

At this moment they were hailed by a voice from the sloop and a few seconds later men, servants and baggage were aboard. The captain was only waiting for his passengers; hardly had they put foot on deck ere her head was turned towards Hastings, where they were to disembark. At this instant the three friends turned, in spite of themselves, a last look on the rock, upon the menacing figure which pursued them and now stood out with a distinctness still. Then a voice reached them once more, sending this threat: 'To our next meeting, sirs, in England.'

As to what you say about not seeing you again, I believe not a word of it; with such a heart as yours—and such a sword—one passes through the valley of the shadow of death a dozen times, unscathed and unalarmed. Au revoir, not farewell.

It is unnecessary to say that from the day I saw Raoul I loved him; nevertheless, believe that I heartily pray that I may not become to him a father, however much I might be proud of such a son.

Your

D'Artagnan.

P.S. Be it well understood that the fifty louis which I send are equally for Aramis as for you—for you as Aramis.

Athos smiled, and his fine eye was dimmed by a tear. D'Artagnan, who had loved him so tenderly, loved him still, although a Mazarinist.

'There are the fifty louis, i'faith,' said Aramis, emptying the purse on the table, all bearing the effigy of Louis xiii. 'Well, what shall you do with this money, count? Shall you keep it or send it back?'

'I shall keep it, Aramis, and even though I had no need of it I still should keep it. What is offered from a generous heart should be accepted generously. Take twenty-five of them, Aramis, and give me the remaining twenty-five.'

'All right; I am glad to see you are of my opinion. There now, shall we start?'

'When you like; but have you no groom?'

'No; that idiot Bazin had the folly to make himself verger, as you know, and therefore cannot leave Notre Dame.'

'Very well, take Blaisois, with whom I know not what to do, since I already have Grimaud.'

'Willingly,' said Aramis.

At this moment Grimaud appeared at the door. 'Ready,' said he, with his usual curtness.

'Let us go, then,' said Athos.

to him in my bronze casket at Blois, of which I send you now the key.

Embrace Porthos from Aramis and myself. Adieu, perhaps farewell.

At the hour agreed upon Aramis arrived; he was dressed as an officer and had the old sword at his side which he had drawn so often and which he was more than ever ready to draw.

'By-the-bye,' he said, 'I think that we are decidedly wrong to depart thus, without leaving a line for Porthos and D'Artagnan.'

'The thing is done, dear friend,' said Athos; 'I foresaw that and have embraced them both from you and myself.'

'You are a wonderful man, my dear count,' said Aramis; 'you think of everything.'

'Well, have you made up your mind to this journey?'

'Quite; and now that I reflect about it, I am glad to leave Paris at this moment.'

'And so am I,' replied Athos; 'my only regret is not having seen D'Artagnan; but the rascal is so cunning, he might have guessed our project.'

When supper was over Blaisois entered. 'Sir,' said he, 'here is Monsieur d'Artagnan's answer.'

'But I did not tell you there would be an answer, stupid!' said Athos.

'And I set off without waiting for one, but he called me back and gave me this;' and he presented a little leather bag, plump and giving out a golden jingle.

Athos opened it and began by drawing forth a little note, written in these terms:

My dear Count,

When one travels, and especially for three months, one never has a superfluity of money. Now, recalling former times of mutual distress, I send you half my purse; it is money to obtain which I made Mazarin sweat. Don't make a bad use of it, I entreat you.

Chapter XLIV

Te Deum for the Victory of Lens

THE bustle which had been observed by Henrietta Maria and for which she had vainly sought to discover a reason, was occasioned by the battle of Lens, announced by the prince's messenger, the Duc de Châtillon, who had taken such a noble part in the engagement; he was, besides, charged to hang five and twenty flags, taken from the Lorraine party, as well as from the Spaniards, upon the arches of Notre Dame.

Such news was decisive; it destroyed, in favour of the court, the struggle commenced with parliament. The motive given for all the taxes summarily imposed and to which the parliament had made opposition, was the necessity of sustaining the honour of France and the uncertain hope of beating the enemy. Now, since the affair of Nordlingen, they had experienced nothing but reverses; the parliament had a plea for calling Mazarin to account for imaginary victories, always promised, ever deferred; but this time there really had been fighting, a triumph and a complete one. And this all knew so well that it was a double victory for the court, a victory at home and abroad; so that even when the young king learned the news he exclaimed, 'Ah, gentlemen of the parliament, we shall see what you will say now!' Upon which the queen had pressed the royal child to her heart, whose haughty and unruly sentiments were in such harmony with her own. A council was called on the same evening, but nothing transpired of what had been decided on. It was only known that on the following Sunday a *Te Deum* would be sung at Notre Dame in honour of the victory of Lens.

The following Sunday, then, the Parisians arose with joy; at that period a *Te Deum* was a grand affair; this kind of ceremony had not then been abused and it produced a great effect. The shops were deserted, houses closed; every one wished to see the young king with his mother, and the famous Cardinal Mazarin whom they hated so much that no one wished to be deprived of his presence. Moreover, great liberty prevailed throughout the immense crowd; every opinion was openly expressed and chorused, so to speak, of coming insurrection, as the thousand bells of all the Paris churches rang out the *Te Deum*. The police belonging to the city being formed by the city itself, nothing threatening presented itself to disturb this concert of universal hatred or freeze the frequent scoffs of slanderous lips.

Nevertheless, at eight o'clock in the morning the regiment of the queen's guards, commanded by Guitant, under whom was his nephew Comminges, marched publicly, preceded by drums and trumpets, filing off from the Palais Royal as far as Notre Dame, a manœuvre which the Parisians witnessed tranquilly, delighted as they were with military music and brilliant uniforms.

Friquet had put on his Sunday clothes, under the pretext of having a swollen face which he had managed to simulate by introducing a handful of cherry kernels into one side of his mouth, and had procured a whole holiday from Bazin. On leaving Bazin, Friquet started off to the Palais Royal, where he arrived at the moment of the turning out of the regiment of guards; and as he had only gone there for the enjoyment of seeing it and hearing the music, he took his place at their head, beating the drum on two pieces of slate and passing from that exercise to that of the trumpet, which he counterfeited quite naturally with his mouth in a manner which had more than once called forth the praises of amateurs of imitative harmony.

This amusement lasted from the Barrière des Sergens to the place of Notre Dame, and Friquet found in it very real enjoyment; but when at last the regiment separated, penetrated the heart of the city and placed itself at the extremity of the Rue Saint Christophe, near the Rue Cocatrix, in which Broussel lived, then Friquet remembered that he had not had breakfast; and after thinking in which direction he had better turn his steps in order to accomplish this important act of the day, he reflected

belongs to the Fronde and you to the queen of England. So, if the second matter which you regret being unable to attend to is not more important than the first— '

'Oh! that is of the first importance.'

'Attend to it, then, at once.'

'Unfortunately, it is a thing that I can't perform at any time I choose. It was arranged for the evening and no other time will serve.'

'I understand,' said Athos smiling, 'midnight.'

'About that time.'

'But, my dear fellow, those are things that bear postponement and you must put it off, especially with so good an excuse to give on your return— '

'Yes, if I return.'

'If you do not return, how does it concern you? Be reasonable. Come, you are no longer twenty years old.'

'To my great regret, *mordieu!* Ah, if I were but twenty years old!'

'Yes,' said Athos, 'doubtless you would commit great follies! But now we must part. I have one or two visits to make and a letter yet to write. Call for me at eight o'clock or shall I wait supper for you at seven?'

'That will do very well,' said Aramis. 'I have twenty visits to make and as many letters to write.'

They then separated. Athos went to pay a visit to Madame de Vendôme, left his name at Madame de Chevreuse's and wrote the following letter to D'Artagnan:

> Dear Friend,
>
> I am about to set off with Aramis on important business. I wished to make my adieux to you, but time does not permit. Remember that I write to you now to repeat how much affection for you I still cherish.
>
> Raoul is gone to Blois and is ignorant of my departure; watch over him in my absence as much as you possibly can; and if by chance you receive no news of me three months hence, tell him to open a packet which he will find addressed